the peace and laid the foundation for the further flourishing of the German Democratic Republic.9

West German politicians went into overdrive. Speaking in Bonn on 18 August, Adenauer said the GDR's 'illegal measures' filled the Federal Government with concern and disgust and were in flagrant contradiction to the four-power agreements on the freedom to move about in Berlin. 'I am sorry to state that this act of arbitrariness has taken place with the approval of the USSR, the leading power of the Warsaw Pact. Through this approval, the Soviet Government contradicts its constant protestations that it wants to solve the Germany and Berlin issues through negotiations.'10 That very same day, 18 August, the Soviet Union sent a note to the United States giving full support for the GDR's 'effective control on the border with West Berlin in order to bar the way for subversive activity being carried out from West Berlin against the GDR'. The note stated that West Berlin had been transformed into a centre of 'subversive activity, diversion and espionage, into a centre of political and economic provocations against the GDR, the Soviet Union, and other socialist countries'. Furthermore:

Former and present West Berlin municipal leaders have cynically called West Berlin an 'arrow in the living body of the German Democratic Republic', a 'front city', a 'violator of tranquillity', the 'cheapest atom bomb put in the centre of a socialist state'. The gates of West Berlin have been opened to international criminals and provocateurs of all kinds, if only to sharpen international tension and widen the dimensions of the provocations and subversive acts against the countries of the socialist community.

'The GDR,' the note concluded, had displayed, over the course of many years, 'great tolerance in the face of such a completely disgraceful and impermissible situation', and by implementing its 'peace-loving and democratic policy', it had borne 'enormous sacrifices'.11